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Testing Plan: Effortless Returns

1. Refined problem statement

We narrowed "busy consumer" to people who return items often, and we treat the pain as a hypothesis to test, not a fact.

Problem statement. Frequent online shoppers face friction when returning unwanted physical items because navigating packaging rules, carrier trips, and tight deadlines turns returns into separate time-consuming errands, leading to postponed actions and forfeited refunds.

- **Project:** Return an unwanted or no-longer-needed physical item to the right company.
- **Urgency:** A late return can mean a lost refund, a fee, or continued responsibility for equipment the person no longer needs.
- **Options today:** Take it to a store, carrier, or drop-off point; schedule a pickup when offered; ask someone else to do it; or wait until another errand makes it convenient.
- **Limitations:** Locations, packaging rules, deadlines, and operating hours differ by company. Even when the handoff itself is straightforward, preparing and arranging the return may require additional effort and be easy to postpone.

What we do not know yet: how often this happens, how much it costs people in money and time, whether the trip or the packaging is the real friction, and who (if anyone) already pays to avoid it. The interviews are built to answer those four questions.

2. Personas and ICP hypothesis

We have identified two potential user personas. Phase 1 will focus on frequent online shoppers with recent return attempts, including both completed and uncompleted returns.

Persona	Type	Who they are (hypothesis)	Screener
A. Frequent online shopper	User	Works full time, shops online across several retailers, mostly apparel, shoes, or home goods; returns feel like a chore squeezed between other obligations	Attempted to return 2+ online purchases in the last 3 months. Attempts that were abandoned or missed the deadline also count.

B. Equipment returner	User	Has rented, leased, or subscribed to physical equipment (modem or cable box, rented gear, subscription hardware) and must send it back after cancelling or upgrading	Returned or still holds equipment they no longer need within the last 6 months

Phase 1 (9/22 to 9/28): Focus on Persona A only, with a target of three completed interviews and four scheduled slots. After reviewing the findings, we will decide whether to interview more people from Persona A or explore Persona B in a separate round.

ICP hypothesis (consumer side): We hypothesize that our ideal customers are frequent online shoppers who repeatedly struggle to fit returns into their routines and may value assistance that reduces the time and coordination involved. We adapt the course's company-focused ICP framework to individual consumers below. These characteristics remain hypotheses to investigate.

ICP Dimension	**Initial Hypothesis**
Consumer & geographic characteristics	Shoppers who have completed or attempted at least two returns in the past three months while balancing work or other responsibilities. We expect stronger needs when drop-off locations require a separate trip or have inconvenient operating hours.
Technographic characteristics	Shoppers familiar with online shopping and digital return instructions who may be comfortable arranging assistance online. Limited access to printing or packaging supplies may create additional friction.
Behavioral & engagement characteristics	Shoppers who have delayed returns, kept unwanted purchases, or sought help because returning items was inconvenient. Previous spending to save time may indicate potential fit, but willingness to pay for return assistance remains unverified.
Strategic alignment & ideal qualities	Shoppers with recurring needs who value a simple process may be more likely to use assistance repeatedly. Retention, referrals, and profitability require later validation. If pickup is pursued, geographically concentrated demand may help reduce service costs.

Buyer side (parked): We are not interviewing retailers or returns-desk staff this round. We will test who pays through what consumers have already spent to avoid the errand (hypothesis H5).

Participant selection: We will recruit people who meet the recent return activity criteria, including those who find returns easy. This will help us understand which circumstances create problems. We will recruit beyond close friends and family; classmates will be used for practice interviews only.

3. Hypotheses to test

We will explore five hypotheses and look for both supporting and challenging evidence to guide our next round of research.

#	Hypothesis	Supporting evidence	Challenging evidence
H1	Frequency: our target users return items often enough to feel a recurring pain	Most describe 1+ return per month, or vivid stories from the last few weeks	Returns are rare and they struggle to recall the last one
H2	Effort: the friction is the trip, packaging, and label, not the decision to return	They name travel, boxing, printing, or hours before anything else	They say the return itself is easy and the pain is elsewhere (refund speed, item quality)
H3	Postponement has a cost: returns get delayed until money or time is lost	Real stories of missed windows, fees, kept items, or unreturned equipment	Almost everyone returns on time without effort
H4	Workarounds: people already trade money or favors to avoid the errand	They paid for pickup or shipping, asked someone, or bundled trips on purpose	They shrug it off and have never changed their behavior
H5	Payment: people have already spent money to make returns easier	They paid for pickup, a return service, or a shipping upgrade to skip the errand	No one has ever paid to avoid the errand/reduce return effort

For each hypothesis, we will record both supporting and challenging evidence. These interviews will help refine our assumptions rather than conclusively confirm or reject them. A lack of previous payment will be treated as missing evidence of paid demand, rather than proof that nobody would pay.

4. Interview question outline

Every question asks for a story from the past or present, never a prediction, and none mentions our idea. If we catch ourselves asking "would you...", we stop and rephrase.

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Opening (about 1 minute): "We're students at Duke learning how people handle everyday errands. We're not selling anything. Is it okay if I record so I can focus on listening? It takes about 20 minutes."

Top 3 questions if time runs short: 1, 3, and 7.

Persona A (Phase 1) and Persona B (Phase 2): consumer guide

#	Type	Question	Follow-up probe
1	Context	Tell me about the last thing you returned. Walk me through it from the moment you decided to send it back.	And then what happened? Where were you? How many returns have you completed or attempted in the past three months?
2	Context	How do you keep track of return deadlines and what you need to do for each one?	Who or what reminds you?
3	Problem	Which parts of that return were easy? Was anything difficult or inconvenient?	What made that part easy or difficult?
4	Problem	How long did it sit before you acted on it? What was it waiting on?	What else was competing for that time?
5	Problem	Have you ever missed a return window or decided not to complete a return?	What did it cost you?
6	Emotion	How would you describe your overall experience with returning items compared to other everyday errands?	What made it feel that way?
7	Alternative	What have you tried to make returns easier?	What worked? What did not?
8	Alternative	Why do you stick with your current way of returning things? What stops you from doing it differently?	Have you ever switched? What triggered it?
9	Behavior	When was the last time you paid money, or asked someone for a favor, to avoid a return errand?	How did you decide it was worth it?
10	Context	Who else is involved when something needs to go back, such as a household member or a coworker?	What do they handle?

Closing: "Is there anything I should have asked?" and "Who else deals with this that I could talk to?"

5. Roles, targets, and timing

Targeting & Timing:

We are conducting Phase 1 from Wednesday 9/23 to Friday 9/25, targeting 4 completed interviews across two parallel tracks (2 slots per pair, plus optional buffer slots for no-shows or reschedules). Our minimum requirement is 3 completed sessions to meet the Phase 1 goal.

Team Setup & Structure:

To avoid overwhelming participants with a 4-person panel and ensure natural, candid conversations, the team will split into two interview pairs (2 teammates per interview: 1 Lead Interviewer and 1 Note-taker/Observer) and a rotation system will be implemented.

- **Pair 1:** Aditya & Gayatri
- **Pair 2:** Shweta & Ziyan Bi

Responsibilities:

- **Lead Interviewer:** Guides the conversation using open-ended questions, manages pacing, and ensures no solution-bias is introduced.
- **Note-taker / Observer:** Manages recording/consent, tracks non-verbal cues, captures verbatim quotes, and logs key data points directly into the shared Learning Log.
- **All Teammates:** Jointly source and screen participants from networks. Practice interviews will be conducted internally prior to the live sessions.

By September 28, we will review the findings together, revise our problem statement and ICP hypothesis, and decide which user group or unanswered questions to explore next.